

Chinese Education & Society

ISSN: 1061-1932 (Print) 1944-7116 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/mced20

High-Level Open Cooperation in Vocational Education: Purpose, Criteria and Pathways—Observations on Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education

Wang Yi, Liang Chen & Chen Yemiao

To cite this article: Wang Yi, Liang Chen & Chen Yemiao (2025) High-Level Open Cooperation in Vocational Education: Purpose, Criteria and Pathways—Observations on Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education, Chinese Education & Society, 58:5-6, 286-302, DOI: 10.1080/10611932.2025.2605002

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/10611932.2025.2605002

Published online: 15 May 2026.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 25

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Citing articles: 1 View citing articles

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=mced20

CHINESE EDUCATION & SOCIETY
2025, VOL. 58, NOS. 5–6, 286–302
https://doi.org/10.1080/10611932.2025.2605002

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Check for updates

High-Level Open Cooperation in Vocational Education: Purpose, Criteria and Pathways—Observations on Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education

Wang Yi[a], Liang Chen[b], and Chen Yemiao[a]

[a]Teachers College for Vocational and Technical Education, Nanning Normal University; [b]College of Education, Zhejiang Normal University

ABSTRACT

Perfecting the systems and mechanisms for high-level openness to the outside world is an important requirement from the 3rd Plenum of the Party's 20th Central Committee, and steadily promoting high-level openness to the outside world in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education is an important means of deepening the Chinese-ASEAN community of common destiny as well as deepening and solidifying the "Belt and Road" Initiative. Theoretically speaking, high-level open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education is a necessary choice to build a great power in vocational education, and it is also an important means of improving the international influence of Chinese vocational education. In practice, it is necessary to regard the perfection of a unified policy system as the logical premise, the creation of high-quality open platforms as the basis, and the construction of a diversified, cooperative educational community as the central task in forming a unified, open Chinese-ASEAN system for vocational education. Accordingly, in order for Chinese-ASEAN vocational education to achieve further high-level openness, it is necessary to build a policy system for institutional Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education based on systems thinking; to optimize the construction of internationalized platforms, steadily opening up new areas for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education; and to place emphasis on shaping the ecology to create open, cooperative ecological circles for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education.

KEYWORDS

Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education; high-level open cooperation; internationalization of vocational education; vocational education

Openness is the distinctive symbol of Chinese-style modernization. The 3rd Plenum of the Party's 20th Central Committee stated: "Uphold the promotion of reforms through openness, and rely on the advantages of our country's super-large-scale market to improve the capacity for openness in expanding international cooperation and build a new system for an open economy at a higher level." We can see that high-level openness plays an important role in highlighting our country's market advantages, integrating international resources, optimizing the landscape for economic development, building a new economic system, and other areas. With respect to vocational education, upholding high-level openness to the outside world plays an important, guiding role in optimizing the operational concepts of vocational education, expanding operational

CONTACT Chen Yemiao 896965826@qq.com Nanning Normal University (Mingxiu Campus), 175 Mingxiu East Road, Xixiangtang District, Nanning, Guangxi, China.

English translation © 2026 Taylor & Francis, Inc., from the Chinese text by Wang Yi, Liang Chen, and Chen Yemiao. Translated by Carissa Fletcher. Originally published in *Vocational and Technical Education*, 2024.

resources for vocational education, enriching the forms of cooperation in vocational education, and so on. As the place of vocational education as a category continues to be established, the place of vocational education as a new strategic resource has increasingly been highlighted. From the perspective of the internal environment, the development of emergent productive forces presents new requirements and challenges for reforms to our country's modern industrial system and the restructuring of production capacity, and a high number of high-tech, skilled talents are urgently needed to negotiate with them. In terms of the external environment, as China's international influence steadily improves and the "Belt and Road" Initiative continues to be deepened, there is an exigent need for solid support from a multitude of talented "ASEAN experts" familiar with ASEAN localization. As a priority region in the "Belt and Road" Initiative, ASEAN's development in cooperation with China has undergone a shift from the mutual trust between good neighbors to the establishment of strategic partnerships, and from thence to the construction of the community of common destiny and comprehensive strategic partnerships, and it has already become one of China's most robust counterparts among its partnerships for international dialogue (Gongjian 2024). As the new open landscape is further deepened, exploring open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation has important strategic significance as well as a practical role in the deepening of talent development in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education, school-business cooperation, the restructuring of production capacity, and so on.

The Value and Purpose of High-Level Open Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education

Education has been the forerunner, beneficiary and promoter of the Opening and Reforms (Baosheng 2018). As an important avenue for boosting the "Belt and Road" Initiative, Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education has an important role and function. Expanding Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education at a high level must be based on the existing Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education and founded upon the basic requirements for building a great power in education, to improve the international influence and level of development of our country's vocational education through transregional cooperation and exchanges in vocational education.

High-Level Open Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education is an Important Means of Aiding in the Realization of the Country's Broader Diplomatic Interests

Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education has natural regional advantages as well as cultural advantages: Since the ASEAN-China Free Trade Area came into being, relations between the two sides have gradually developed from a shallow level to a comprehensive strategic partnership on a deeper level, and the issuance of a series of policy documents and cooperative agreements has ushered in new areas for bilateral cooperation in vocational education. First, on a national level, in recent years, our country has actively introduced corresponding policy measures on a strategic

level to promote high-quality cooperation and implementation of Chinese-ASEAN vocational education and, guided by the framework and trends of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation, the two sides constantly issue related policy documents, not only specifying their resolve regarding the digitalized transformation of education and training of advanced digital talents, but also expanding the space for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in education (Min and Zaoming 2023). For instance, "China-ASEAN Strategic Partnership Vision 2030" (中国—东盟战略伙伴关系 2030 年愿景 Zhongguo-Dongmeng zhanlüe huoban guanxi 2030 nian yuanjing) places emphasis on "strengthening educational innovation and academic exchanges through the China-ASEAN Education Cooperation Week and other platforms," and so on. Driven by upgrading of the ASEAN-China Free Trade Area, the implementation of the "Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership" (区域全面经济伙伴关系协定 Quyu quanmian jingji huoban guanxi xieding) (RCEP), a framework for institutional openness in Chinese-ASEAN educational cooperation has gradually taken shape. Second, on a governmental level, governments serve as the proponents of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, and they are actively promoting the steady advancement of bilateral cooperation through related policy support, economic support, personnel exchanges and other forms and avenues. Each local government is actively leveraging its own guiding role to promote a dynamic response to the requirements of the "Belt and Road" Initiative in vocational education in the given region, guiding vocational colleges and universities as well as trades and businesses in the given region to actively promote cooperation with the nations of ASEAN in vocational education. For instance, Tianjin is actively relying on the Bohai "Luban Workshop" to encourage vocational colleges and universities to engage in cooperation with the nations of ASEAN; in 2016, the Institute of Technology Ayothaya of Thailand registered the establishment of a "Luban Workshop," which was our country's first "Confucius Institute" in the field of vocational education to be established overseas (Zhidong and Peng 2016); as of 2024, Guangxi has actively engaged with various institutions of higher education within the United Nations as well as the nations of ASEAN to create projects for the construction of around 10 Chinese-ASEAN institutes for technological innovation (Autonomous Region Department of Education 2023), the establishment of a total of 17 Chinese-ASEAN institutes for modern craftsmanship in the nations of ASEAN, as well as the establishment of the Chinese-ASEAN Think Tank for Industrial and Educational Development. Third, on a popular level, Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education has chiefly unfolded on the level of schools, often appearing in the form of cooperative coalitions, exchange weeks, et cetera; on the basis of the China-ASEAN Expo, the China-ASEAN Joint Exhibition and Forum on Vocational Education and so on have been held; and related research centers and think tanks have been established, such as the China-ASEAN Center for Research on Vocational Education, the China-ASEAN Center for Research on Educational and Cultural Development, the China-ASEAN Think Tank for Research on the Development of Vocational Education, and so on. In summary, through untiring efforts and promotion by all sides, Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education has become an important brand and format for boosting our country's establishment of great power diplomacy. In 2024, Wang Yi 王毅, a member of the Politburo, the Director of the Office of the Central Foreign Affairs Commission, and the Minister of Foreign Affairs,

noted while attending the China-ASEAN Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Vientiane that bilateral Chinese-ASEAN cooperation exhibits the characteristics of increasingly close economic and trade ties, swiftly recovering humanistic exchanges, deepening and consolidation of interconnection, a continuous surge of fresh vitality, and so on (Ministry of Foreign Affairs 2024). It can thus be seen that, in the wake of further deepening and promotion of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation, high-level open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education is certain to become an important direction in the process of the internationalization of Chinese vocational education.

High-Level Open Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education Is an Inevitable Choice in Building a Great Power in Vocational Education

The crux of a great power in education rests in being a great power of people, and the people's strength is the fundamental underpinning that supports the high-quality realization of a great power in education. From an essential perspective, the people's strength includes three dimensions, namely, the people's physical strength and mental strength as well as the strength of their abilities. Among these, physical strength is the foundation, mental strength is the objective, and the strength of abilities is the core. For an individual, abilities manifests as their own ability to store knowledge, employability, and so on, and the fundamental element that pervades an individual's abilities is the learning in which they engage on the basis of their specialization and vocation. Furthermore, as an undertaking for training people, vocational education inevitably must constantly engage in optimization and adjustment of its own concepts of talent development and methods of talent development. This optimization and adjustment not only must be founded upon the respective characteristics of vocational education, to achieve its purification and perfection, but must also properly rely on the external environment for the development of vocational education, to open up new avenues for cooperation in vocational education. One could say that the essence of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education rests in improving the capacity for and level of internationalized talent development in vocational education. This manifests in three areas. First, high-level open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education broadens the positional horizons for talent development. In the traditional process of cooperation in vocational education, talent development is founded upon the given country's needs for economic development, the concepts, methods and so on for talent development emphasize industry in the given country or region as a benchmark, and cooperation and exchanges in vocational education feature a certain degree of "exclusivity." But high-level open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education must be founded upon performing integrated remolding of the concepts, methods, models and so on for talent development in vocational education from the perspective of restructuring of international production capacity and the needs of industrial transformation, further promoting profound interconnection between and harmonization of the Chinese model for the development of vocational education and international forms of cooperation in vocational education, and exploring individual concepts for talent development in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education within the generic qualities of international development of vocational

education. Second, high-level open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education extends the domain for cooperation in vocational education. Within the trend of high-level openness, by placing Chinese-ASEAN vocational education within the practical framework of the Chinese-ASEAN cooperative community, the community is embodied as an allied group founded upon collective objectives for development, and within this context, Chinese-ASEAN vocational education absolutely must shift from cooperation on a shallow level to cooperation on a deeper, more substantive level, engaging in the in-depth distillation of the framework and mission of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education from the perspective of industrial collaboration, cooperation between colleges and universities, sharing of resources, and so on. Third, high-level open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education reshapes the ecological circle for cooperation in vocational education. High-quality, open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education not only must be founded upon Chinese-ASEAN vocational education itself, but must also optimize the internal and external ecological structure for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, with each participating entity on both sides implementing reciprocal sharing of benefits and exchanges of resources through dialogue and cooperation and revolving around the needs of cooperation, to achieve profound bilateral cooperation in the areas of government policies, culture, science and technology, infrastructure, the transformation of scientific and technological research and development, and so on, and to truly realize mutual harmonization and reciprocal mutualism within the internal and external ecological systems for open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education.

High-Level Open Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education Is an Important Means of Improving the International Influence of Chinese Vocational Education

The essential objective of high-level open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education rests in shaping the status and discursive power of Chinese vocational education within international cooperation in vocational education and educational practices. The international influence of Chinese vocational education has the dual connotations of "the international influence of vocational education" and "improving international influence through vocational education": The former points to recognition and acceptance of Chinese vocational education by the international community, placing particular emphasis on the discursive power of Chinese vocational education within the external environment of international development of vocational education, while the latter emphasizes the quality of vocational education itself, requiring that the influence of Chinese vocational education be enhanced by improving the level of development of vocational education, and both are interdependent and mutually promoting. The essential pathways for improving the international influence of Chinese vocational education manifest in two areas, that is, internal demand and external shaping, and the core element that permeates internal demand and external shaping is open cooperation. By taking Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education as the subject of observation and study, it is evident that the international influence

displayed by Chinese-ASEAN vocational education is naturally also determined by Chinese-ASEAN vocational education itself as well as the external environment for the development of Chinese-ASEAN vocational education. On the one hand, high-level open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education can aid Chinese higher vocational colleges and universities in going global with high quality and achieving internationalization. The internationalization of higher vocational colleges and universities is a role that must actively participate in the course of international cooperation: The internationalization of higher vocational colleges and universities manifests as higher vocational colleges and universities actively participating in the practices of talent development in international vocational education and consciously fuzing their own operational concepts with the trends of development of international vocational education; at the same time, it also includes the internationalization of instructors, that is, establishing and optimizing the teaching faculty for different categories, trades and so on, to improve the quality and level of talent development at vocational colleges and universities. On the other hand, high-level open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education can aid Chinese businesses in going global and achieving internationalization. The continuous deepening of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation will inevitably require many internationalized talents who are familiar with ASEAN and understand ASEAN to support the development of Chinese businesses in the regions of ASEAN. The latest data from the General Administration of Customs shows that, in 2023, trade between our country and ASEAN continued to maintain growth, with the scale reaching 6.41 trillion yuan, and ASEAN has maintained its position as our country's top trade partner for four years running (Office of Reforms and Development for Guangxi Zhuang Autonomous Region Industrial Park 2024). Simultaneous with the development of economic and trade cooperation in depth and breadth, a high number of talents are inevitably required, which presents new challenges as well as opportunities for bilateral cooperation in vocational education. According to a forecast report by the World Bank, by 2030, the joint construction of "Belt and Road" transportation facilities will result in 2.8–9.7% growth in trade for economies along the line, and will drive 1.7–6.2% growth in the global volume of trade (Xinhua Institute 2023). It is thus evident that, in the current process of internationalized development, transcultural, highly skilled emerging internationalized talents with cross-cultural communicative competence and familiarity with the culture of the given region will still be an obstacle constraining our country's businesses in going global. Furthermore, high-level open cooperation with the outside world will inevitably become an important pathway for cultivating internationalized talents and improving the international contributions of our country's vocational education in the future.

The Logical Criteria for High-Level Open Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education

Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education is continuously deepening as an accompaniment to the deepening of the Chinese-ASEAN community of common destiny, the "Belt and Road" initiative, and so on. In recent years, both sides have engaged in multifaceted cooperation revolving around talent development, international

student education, industrial cooperation, cross-border educational operations, and so on, but they also face new opportunities and new challenges.

Perfecting a Unified Policy System is the Paramount Task in Deepening the Openness of Chinese-ASEAN Vocational Education to the Outside World

Policies are beacons supporting the deepening, stabilization and substantiation of Chinese-ASEAN vocational education, and perfecting a collaborative policy system can further aid both sides in engaging in highly efficient cooperation. In the existing process of open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, due to the influence of the broad area, differences in national development, differences in social systems, and other factors involved in the process of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, the result is that it is difficult for the cohesion formed by the policy system to be fully demonstrated in the course of practices. First, central policy planning is weak. Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education belongs to the cross-regional category, featuring transregionality and complexity, and it requires engagement in holistic, systematic thinking and mastery. Although the texts of existing policies on vocational education actively advocate the internationalization of vocational education and encourage vocational colleges and universities as well as businesses to go global, they do not yet provide clear requirements and stipulations as to relevant specific requirements, measures, mechanisms and so on. On the whole, there are systemic gaps in the design of systems for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education from the national to the local levels, with the result that it is difficult for cooperative planning, cooperative arrangements and so on in Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education to leverage the institutional advantages of our country's concentration of forces to handle matters of great significance (Qiufeng and Manfu 2021). Second, the orientation of the regionalized policy system is unclear, and it lacks detailed localized cooperative planning. Localized cooperation in vocational education is an important element supporting the generation of the characteristics of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education: Existing cooperation in vocational education and so on largely relies on the implementation of the "China-ASEAN Strategic Partnership Vision 2030," "Joint Statement on Interlinkage and Cooperation Between the 'Belt and Road' Initiative and the 'Master Plan on ASEAN Connectivity 2025'" (关于"一带一路"倡议同〈东盟互联互通总体规划 2025 〉对接合作的联合声明 Guanyu "Yi dai yi lu" changyi tong Dongmeng hulian hutong zongti guihua 2025′ duijie hezuo de lianhe shengming) and other documents on cooperation, but there are relatively few targeted texts regarding Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education; at the same time, relevant documents concerning Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education within each region also largely unfold revolving around holistic cooperation, and there are relatively few policy documents aimed at mining the characteristics of the given region and country-specific cooperation among the ten nations of ASEAN, with the result that it is difficult to highlight and demonstrate the localized features of policies in Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education. Finally, in the process of promoting Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, experience in drafting policies on vocational education itself is lacking, and

actors' policy costs are disregarded. Influenced by the history, foundation, and other factors in the respective development of our country's vocational education, our country's experience in internationalized cooperation in vocational education is comparatively deficient. Especially while Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education is still in the exploratory stage, the lack of corresponding experience and references in the area of policy drafting has resulted in inadequate attention to the interests of both sides in existing policies.

The Creation of High-Quality Platforms Open to the Outside World is the Premise and Foundation for Deepening Outward Openness in Chinese-ASEAN Vocational Education

Platforms are the foundation supporting the high-quality promotion and implementation of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, and are also important vehicles for the high-quality promotion of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education; strengthening research on platforms is an important element of the current process of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education that cannot be disregarded. In recent years, revolving around the deepening of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation, various participating entities have engaged in in-depth exploration and practice, creating immense platforms for foreign exchanges and cooperation in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education. In terms of the nature of the platforms, the platforms for Chinese-ASEAN vocational education can be divided into three categories, namely, research platforms guided by theory, research platforms guided by practice, and comprehensive practical platform combining theory and practice. Among these, the research platforms guided by theory are largely led by governments, universities and so on, and this type of platform focuses on basic theoretical research on Chinese-ASEAN vocational education: In the example of the Center for Research on Chinese-ASEAN Vocational Education, the basic orientation of this center is geared toward engagement in cutting-edge academic research on China and the nations of ASEAN, providing consulting services for policy decisions, undertaking precise, specialized training, and building internationalized platforms. In recent years, in the wake of the deepening of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation on vocational education and the requirements of research, ten country-specific research institutes focusing on the ten nations of ASEAN have furthermore been established, with Brunei in the lead, gradually forming arrangements for engagement in comprehensive research on a profound level aimed at ASEAN vocational education. The research platforms guided by practice are chiefly dominated by institutions on the front lines of practices in vocational education, with such institutions consisting largely of vocational colleges and universities. For instance, in 2022, Beijing Tang Chinese Education & Technology Ltd. cooperated with Tangshan Vocational & Technical College to establish the China-Malaysia College of International Education in Malaysia. The platforms combining theory and practice are chiefly established through joint coordination by multiple agents, and this type of platform has the characteristic of comprehensiveness. Examples include the China-ASEAN Technical Education Cooperation Platform (CATECP), the China-ASEAN Education League, the China-ASEAN Federation for Vocational Education, and so on. Among these, the China-ASEAN Federation for Vocational Education is jointly sponsored

by 175 vocational colleges and universities, polytechnic universities, research institutes, trades and businesses from China and various ASEAN nations participating in the "China-ASEAN Double Hundred Vocational College Flagship Cooperation Program (2018–2022)" (中国—东盟双百职校强强合作旗舰计划[2018–2022] Zhongguo-Dongmeng shuang bai zhixiao qiangqiang hezuo qijian jihua [2018–2022]), collectively composed of 98 Chinese institutions and 77 institutions from the ten member states of ASEAN. Simultaneous with the full-scale development of the multitude of research platforms, there have also been private concerns. One is that sharing of platform resources between regions and the degree of consolidation await further enhancement. With respect to the distribution of the research platforms, influenced by regional factors as well as the factors of economic development, they largely exhibit a dynamic distribution: For instance, Guangxi has exploited its regional advantages to actively promote Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education as well as cooperation in vocational education on the border; Jiangsu, Shandong, Zhejiang and so on have fully leveraged their industrial and economic advantages to actively engage in cooperation in vocational education with Thailand, Cambodia, Malaysia and other countries, et cetera. However, relative to these regions, other inland provinces are often at a disadvantage, and though there is cooperation, the results are poor. Second, the platforms have unclear orientations, with fairly significant clustering. From the perspective of existing practices and research findings, the establishment of the current Chinese-ASEAN platforms for cooperation in vocational education was largely premised upon being guided by their own specialized development and influenced by international trends: Since 2021, the number of platforms in the category of finance, economics and commerce has swiftly grown, whereas Chinese-ASEAN platforms for international cooperation in vocational education have yet to be established within the category of resources, the environment and safety, the category of water conservancy, and other specialized fields (Zhongchang and Jia 2023). Third, theoretical research and the development of practices need to be further strengthened. From the perspective of existing research, relevant theoretical findings focusing on Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education seem to be somewhat thin: As the degree of internationalization of Chinese vocational education deepens, practices in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education will inevitably require support from a solid theoretical foundation so as to achieve highly efficient advancement, but actual research largely focuses on empirical research on Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, and the means of transforming empirical research into theoretical research will certainly be a new problem that should be considered in the construction of platforms for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education.

Building a Diverse, Collaborative Educational Community is the Central Task in Achieving High-Quality Openness to the Outside World in Chinese-ASEAN Vocational Education

As a transregional, transcultural, transconceptual practice of educational cooperation, open Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education requires proper handling of the relationships between various practicing entities, clarification of entities' responsibilities, standardization of entities' rights, and guidance of the various participating

entities to consciously fulfill their obligations, thereby forming a mutually cooperative, mutualistic and reciprocally promoting community for cooperation. The community manifests as a set of relationships formed by the various participating entities revolving around common objectives and linked by a particular pathway, and the ultimate goal of this set rests in achieving reciprocal, common development. The 3rd Plenum of the Party's 20th Central Committee proposed the requirement of constructing a three-dimensional, interconnected network for the "Belt and Road," that is, the need to improve the level and quality of cooperation by different regions and countries with China through ongoing open cooperation. With respect to Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, it is necessary to profoundly explore the Chinese-ASEAN educational community for vocational education under the impetus of the "Belt and Road" Initiative, and shape emergent productive forces for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation. In terms of existing research and practices, the Chinese-ASEAN educational community for vocational education displays a trend of development in depth and breadth, but there are still aspects that urgently need to be perfected. One is that the mechanisms for sharing values are rocky. The essential objective of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education rests in achieving the common development and advancement of China and ASEAN, and consolidating the cohesion in Chinese-ASEAN cooperation. Its values are embodied as sharing of educational values, educational concepts, and other aspects, and due to the influence of differing factors in the respective national systems, level of economic development, industrial structures and other aspects of China and the nations of ASEAN, the result is that conceptual misalignment often arises during the process of actual cooperation, causing cooperation to be at a shallow level, while governments, businesses and trades related to educational operations for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education lack initiative (Chengtao and Qiufeng 2020). Second, the driving forces within industry-education cooperation are inadequate. Industry-education fusion and school-business cooperation are important starting points for the implementation of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, but there is poor collaboration between schools and businesses that are synchronously going global in current Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, with the result that the supply of high-caliber, internationalized talents cannot be assured for businesses in the process of going global, which ultimately influences the depth and breadth of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education. At the same time, with respect to the interconnection of academic qualifications, cooperating parties are unable to properly perfect the mechanisms of interconnection for bilateral cooperation, with the result that it is difficult for the two sides to achieve balance in terms of academic qualifications, leading to the squandering of resources for talent development, and directly manifesting as the lack of a regional framework for qualifications in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education, mechanisms for school-business collaboration in "going global" that still need optimization, and so on (Qi and Juxia 2020). Third, the level of internationalization of vocational colleges and universities must still be further improved. Vocational colleges and universities are the main battlefields for deepening Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, and their level of internationalization determines the level of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education. Influenced by the level of development of our country's vocational colleges and universities themselves

as well as the degree of international recognition, in current Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, vocational colleges and universities largely take an experiential approach to cooperation, blindly pushing forward on holistic cooperation, whilst being limited by cooperation with unscreened schools and contracts; furthermore, relevant cooperation largely focuses on the imparting of basic knowledge and simple skills, remaining on the shallow level of sites, course resources, learning materials and so on. Relevant cooperation projects have unfolded relatively slowly, and reciprocal recognition of courses, credits, qualifications and so on has also been quite limited (Maolin and Xiaoyuan 2019).

Strategic Pathways for High-Level Open Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education

Build an Institutional Policy System for Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education Founded Upon Systems Thinking

Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education is an important element of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation, and the 3rd Plenum of the Party's 20th Central Committee proposed a requirement for steady expansion of institutional openness, where institutional openness involves the standardization of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation from the institutional dimension. Furthermore, with respect to Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, building an institutional system for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education requires that detailed planning and designs be produced with respect to Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education from the top dimension, so as to avoid disorder, fracturing and displacement of institutions in the process of existing practices. Here, disorder refers to a lack of unified requirements and objectives to be implemented in the process of policy drafting and implementation, with the result that policy drafting and implementation cannot achieve the set or expected outcome. Fracturing chiefly refers to weak links between central authorities and localities, localities and schools, and so on, leading to the emergence of corresponding misalignments in the process of implementation. Displacement chiefly refers to the problems of unsteady links, mismatched connections, and other problems arising in the process of implementation due to China and the nations of ASEAN being unable to properly premise the policy drafting process upon their mutual needs. On this basis, to build an institutionalized policy system for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education in the process of implementation, it is first necessary to leverage the positive effects of policies on the foundation of the value of the policies themselves. In the policy drafting process as a whole, the precision, characteristics and agency of policy instruments must be properly improved. The so-called precision of policy instruments means that survey studies should be actively upheld in the process of drafting policies, premised upon the actual foundation of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, and focusing on the current state of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, to formulate guiding, targeted policies on openness in vocational education, and hit the mark in the implementation of policies. The characteristics of policy instruments refer to the necessity of perfecting policies on cooperation in vocational education on the basis of the

characteristics of vocational education as well as the needs of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation, to avoid situations in which the process of drafting policies on Chinese-ASEAN vocational education becomes isolated. The agency of policy instruments means that the role and value of the different participating entities should be actively utilized in the process of drafting cooperation, to avoid a lack of agents in drafting policies on Chinese-ASEAN vocational education. Second, uphold the concept of systematization, to achieve the systematization of policies on Chinese-ASEAN vocational education. Systematization means that emphasis should be placed on vertical communication and horizontal assimilation between policies in the policy process: Vertical communication between policies on Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education means that it is necessary to form integrated links between the "central authorities – provinces – cities – schools," and that the central authorities (at the national level) should actively draft normative documents on Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education revolving around the needs of building the Chinese-ASEAN community of common destiny, wherein such documents are chiefly oriented toward the level of standards and the level of planning, and play the role of controlling the macroscopic direction. At the provincial level, corresponding guiding recommendations should be issued for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education in the given province, on the basis of the macroscopic direction at the national level, with reference to the developmental foundation and industrial structure of the given province; by the same token, this principle should also be upheld at the municipal level. With respect to the level of schools, they are the central implementers of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education; with reference to the state of development of the given school, detailed operating guides and cooperation agreements for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education should be drafted, so as to improve the level of cooperation at the given school. Horizontal assimilation chiefly means that the process of drafting policies on Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education should not be limited to the level of vocational education, but should also actively create connections to other policies, such as frameworks for Chinese-ASEAN economic cooperation in vocational education, policies on Chinese-ASEAN industrial cooperation, and so on, to achieve reciprocal harmonization and mutual promotion between policies. Finally, perfect the referential mechanisms and evaluative mechanisms for policies on Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, to ensure the high efficiency and adaptability of policies. Because Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education is still in a stage of exploration and refining, in the drafting and implementation of corresponding policies, referencing of other countries' policies on cooperation in vocational education should be strengthened, to improve the level of internationalization of policies on Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education. At the same time, mechanisms for the evaluation of policies should also be strengthened: Policy evaluation refers to the comprehensive evaluation of the positive impacts and negative impacts that a policy target and its implementation may produce on society, the economy and the natural environment on the basis of certain subjective value judgments and objective value criteria (Haibo 2004). Not only is it necessary to regularly conduct predictive evaluations and tracking evaluations of policies on Chinese-ASEAN vocational education, in addition, prompt attention should actively be given to the circumstances of drafting, execution, oversight and so on for policies

on Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education in different stages, so as to improve the adaptability of policies on Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, and ensure the equity and quality of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education.

Optimize the Construction of Internationalized Platforms, and Steadily Open Up New Areas for Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education

Internationalized cooperative platforms are an important window for ensuring "bringing in" and "going global" in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education, and high-quality, open cooperative platforms can quickly aid both sides in cooperation in obtaining front-line information on their cooperative partner as well as the requirements for cooperation. The 3rd Plenum of the Party's 20th Central Committee proposed: "Continue to implement the "Belt and Road" action plan for scientific and technological innovation, and strengthen the construction of multilateral cooperative platforms for green development, the digital economy, artificial intelligence, energy, taxation, finance, disaster risk reduction, and other fields." We can see that not only does active advancement of the construction of the "Belt and Road" require engagement in in-depth practices and exploration premised upon the foundation of bilateral cooperation, in addition, national exchanges and cooperation for co-construction of the "Belt and Road" should be expanded through integration in different fields. On the one hand, systematized cooperative platforms must be established. On the basis of the current state of and plans for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, platforms for cooperative exchanges in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education can be divided into two formats, top-down and bottom-up. Among these, the former have governmental characteristics, and are guided by national policies as well as bilateral needs for development. This type of platform has greater influence and authority. In the example of the China "Belt and Road" Portal, this website is a comprehensive exchange platform integrating information, policies, projects, data, services, countries, special sections, and so on. The latter are characterized by autonomy, and are chiefly sponsored and established spontaneously by research institutes and vocational education operators; they mainly consist of exchange platforms collaborating with multiple regions and teams to carry out resource integration and interactions via multiple channels. This type of platform has comparatively weak authority, and consists of comprehensive coalition platforms, such as the China-ASEAN Joint Exhibition and Forum on Vocational Education, the Cooperative Alliance of Chinese-ASEAN Vocational Colleges and Universities, and so on; there are also country-specific, specialized cooperative alliances, such as the China-Vietnam Industry-Education Alliance for Vocational Education, the China-Indonesia Industry-Education Alliance for Vocational Education, the China-ASEAN Alliance for Vocational Education for Transportation, and so on. It is evident that the current Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education largely consists of bottom-up exchange platforms. Therefore, the links and interaction between the two types of exchange platforms should be strengthened to achieve complementarity between the two. On the other hand, it is necessary to implement "point – line – plane" thinking to achieve interlayer coordination of platforms for Chinese-ASEAN

cooperation in vocational education. "Point" thinking chiefly consists of engagement in cooperative exchanges in cooperation with a single institution within bilateral Chinese-ASEAN cooperation; such exchanges largely unfold on the level of schools, with the two parties engaging in corresponding cooperation on the basis of an agreement. The relevant school personnel establish relatively stable mechanisms for visits and exchanges, regularly convene study meetings, publish academic papers, explore talent development standards and models, and so on. This form of cooperative platform often relies on the two parties' internal resources for support, and the sustainability of such partnerships/platforms is not guaranteed. "Line" thinking chiefly refers to engagement in cooperation and exchanges led by trades and industries, and can likewise be divided into two forms, namely, top-down and bottom-up: Governments chiefly take the lead in top-down implementation, which is a form of cooperation with diverse collaboration between governments, trades, businesses and schools. Bottom-up chiefly consists of the joint formation of a corresponding cooperative platform by trade associations, colleges and universities on the foundation of school "point" cooperation, thereby attracting external teams and resources for joint construction. The advantage of top-down establishment of "line"-style platforms rests in having project and policy support for cooperation, while the disadvantage is that it is difficult to swiftly respond to cooperation at the overseas level, with the result that some cooperation is not timely. It is on this level that bottom-up demonstrates its unique advantages, making it easier to establish cooperative relationships and mechanisms for bilateral interaction in the process of implementation. "Plane" thinking emphasizes engagement in cooperation on a holistic level, where this level includes two areas—domestic platforms and cooperative platforms in the nations of ASEAN, with the two parties respectively taking responsibility for matters of cooperation in the different countries; this type of cooperation can often attract premium resources on both sides for participation in cooperation, thereby gaining stable resources and support for Chinese-ASEAN vocational education, but the issue of cooperative links must be properly handled in the process of implementation.

Focus on Shaping the Ecology to Create Ecological Circles for Open, Collaborative Chinese-ASEAN Cooperation in Vocational Education

Quality is a key factor in the development of vocational education, and it is a prerequisite for the successful implementation of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation projects in vocational education (Tirong, Xun, and Jian 2023). Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education is a comprehensive exploration of educational practices, which requires engagement in in-depth reflection on and review of many aspects of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education from a holistic perspective. Premised upon the requirement for planning comprehensive strategic Chinese-ASEAN cooperation as well as the needs of dynamic transformation and restructuring of the regional economy, in the future, it will inevitably be necessary to shift from the current shallow, experiential cooperation to in-depth, meaning-based cooperation in the future. By shaping the ecology of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, adhere to the logic of diversity and robustness in system evolution, build a new framework for cooperation in vocational education that is aligned with China and ASEAN's bilateral

needs for development, and improve the resilience of Chinese-ASEAN vocational education in response to international cooperation on production capacity. First, the development of emergent talents with global competitiveness shall be regarded as the objective. The essential targets of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education should not be limited to China and the nations of ASEAN: Rather, we should have an internationalized vision and global competitiveness, and emergent talents are innovative, "peak" talents conforming to the needs of the development of emergent productive forces and possessing specialized technical characteristics (Fang and Bingyuan 2024). The internal performance of emergent talents in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education comprises their ability to proficiently apply new technologies and tools to adapt to the needs of their jobs, and to shape their own bodies of knowledge through continuous practice; their external performance consists of their ability to astutely capture the trends of restructuring of Chinese-ASEAN production capacity, autonomously integrate themselves into the transformations, and steadily improve their own innovativeness. With respect to Chinese-ASEAN vocational education, guided by emergent talent development, it is necessary to expand the ecosystem for talent development in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education through the optimization of systematic curriculum concepts, industry-education integration, internships, practical training and other elements, and thereby perfect the pathways for talent growth. Second, uphold transregional collaborative governance, and achieve alignment with peers in Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education. Transregional collaborative governance is an important pathway for ensuring the high-quality development of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education. On the one hand, it is necessary to respect the central position of the nations of ASEAN, respect Chinese-ASEAN cultural differences, and explore mechanisms for transregional identity, mechanisms for industry-education integration and collaboration, mechanisms for collaboration between entities, mechanisms for sharing of benefits, et cetera on the foundation of cultural differences, to ensure the subjective position of each entity; on the other hand, digitalized resources should be actively utilized to strengthen the construction of digital platforms for Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education (Min and Zaoming 2024), improve information sharing in emergent talent development, and establish connections between resources for pre-employment education, on-the-job education and post-employment continuing education in talent development in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education, focusing on the needs of talent growth for the entire life cycle in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education, to create avenues for the growth of emergent talents in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education. Finally, rooted in meaning, actively explore the categories and attributes of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education. Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education is an important category of education in the process of high-quality Chinese education opening up to the outside world, and it depends on the unfolding and continuous deepening of the Chinese-ASEAN cooperative relationship; in practice, Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education has accumulated relatively rich practical experience and wisdom, but in the areas of theoretical research, the distillation of experiences, and so on, further improvement and development are still needed. This is because deepening Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education not only requires deepening theoretical research on Chinese-ASEAN vocational education on the basis of the actual foundation of China and the nations of ASEAN, and distilling

theories on transregional cooperation in vocational education in keeping with the characteristics of Chinese-ASEAN vocational education, but also requires strengthening pathways for humanistic education, supported by the education of international students who come to China, placing emphasis on the dissemination and promotion of Chinese culture and, by holistically building a framework of categories for the development of international students who come to China for vocational education, training processes, assurance mechanisms, and so on (Chen and Zouhao 2023), realizing the high-quality development of education for international students who come to China for vocational education, boosting bidirectional interaction in Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education, and promoting the deepening and substantiation of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

2024 Guangxi Key Research Project on Vocational Education and Educational Reforms: "Studies on Pathways to Empowering Emergent Talent Development in Communities for Industry-Education Integration in Chinese-ASEAN Trades" (中国—东盟行业产教融合共同体赋能新质人才培养的路径研究 Zhongguo-Dongmeng hangye chan jiao ronghe gongtongti funeng xinzhi rencai peiyang de lujing yanjiu) (GXGZJG2024A044), Moderator: Chen Yemiao.

Notes on contributors

Wang Yi (1962–), male, is the Standing Deputy Director and Secretary-General of the Center for Research on Chinese-ASEAN Vocational Education, the Standing Deputy Director of the Guangxi Center for Research on the Development of Vocational Education, and a professor and doctoral advisor at the Teachers College for Vocational and Technical Education at Nanning Normal University, research orientation: Chinese-ASEAN vocational education (Nanning, 530001).

Liang Chen (1996–), male, is a doctoral student at the College of Education at Zhejiang Normal University, research orientation: Comparative vocational education.

Chen Yemiao is an assistant research fellow at the Teachers College for Vocational and Technical Education at Nanning Normal University, research orientation: Vocational and technical education studies (Nanning, 530001)

References

Autonomous Region Department of Education. 2023. Bu qu lianhe tuidong Guangxi zhiye jiaoyu gao zhiliang fazhan (Ministries and the region jointly promote the high-quality development of vocational education in Guangxi). *Guangxi ribao* 9:09–13.

Baosheng, C. 2018. Jiaoyu: Gaige kaifang de xianxing zhe, shouyi zhe, zhuli zhe (Education: The forerunner, beneficiary and promoter of the opening and reforms). *Guangming ribao* 6:12–13.

Chen, L., and W. Y. Zouhao. 2023. Yi dai yi lu": Laihua zhijiao liuxuesheng peiyang de liju, kunjing yu lujing (Properly following the "Belt and Road": The motivation, difficulties and pathways for development of international students coming to China for vocational education). *Zhijiao luntan* 9:21–9.

Chengtao, Z., and Z. Qiufeng. 2020. "Yi dai yi lu" shiyu xia Zhongguo-Dongmeng zhiye jiaoyu hezuo de xianshi toushi yu celüe goujian (Actual perspectives and strategic construction of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education within the field of view of the "Belt and Road"). *Jiaoyu yu zhiye* 23:29–36.

Fang, X., and L. Bingyuan. 2024. Xinzhi rencai funeng xinzhi shengchan li de lilun luoji yu xianshi lujing (The theoretical logic and actual pathways for empowerment of emergent productive forces by emergent talents). *Renkou yu jingji* 4:1–6.

Gongjian, W. Y. 2024. Yi dai yi lu": Quanmian zouxiang shijie de Zhongguo-Dongmeng zhiye jiaoyu (Co-constructing the "Belt and Road": Comprehensively moving toward global Chinese-ASEAN vocational education). *Zhiye jishu jiaoyu* 6:1.

Haibo, L. 2004. Zhengce pingjia kuangjia xia de guizhi yingxiang fenxi (Analysis of the influence of regulations within a policy evaluation framework). *Kexue dui shehui de yingxiang* 3:12–5.

Maolin, Z., and L. Xiaoyuan. 2019. Zhongguo-Dongmeng zhiye jiaoyu hudong gongying hezuo jizhi yanjiu (Study of mechanisms for interaction and win-win cooperation in Chinese-ASEAN vocational education). *Zhijiao luntan (Journal of Vocational Education)* 7:165–9.

Min, Z., and M. Zaoming. 2023. "Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in higher education within the field of view of the "Digital Silk Road"). Shuzi sichou zhi lu" shiyu xia Zhongguo-Dongmeng gaodeng jiaoyu hezuo yanjiu (A study of Guangxi shehui kexue) 9:84–91.

Min, Z., and M. Zaoming. 2024. Shuzhi shidai shenhua Zhongguo-Dongmeng zhiye jiaoyu hezuo de yanjiu (Study of the deepening of Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education in the age of digital intelligence). *Jiaoyu yu zhiye* 6:32–7.]

Ministry of Foreign Affairs. 2024. Wang Yi jieshao Zhongguo Dongmeng hezuo fengshuo chengguo (Wang Yi introduces the rich achievements of cooperation between China and ASEAN) [EB/OL]. (07-27-2024) [07-27-2024]. https://www.mfa.gov.cn/wjbzhd/202407/t20240726_11460992.shtml.

Office of Reforms and Development for Guangxi Zhuang Autonomous Region Industrial Park. 2024. Haiguan zongshu: Dongmeng lianxu si nian wei woguo di yi da maoyi huoban (General Administration of Customs: ASEAN is our country's top trade partner for four years running) [EB/OL]. (01-17-2024) [07-26-2024]. http://bbwb.gxzf.gov.cn/zwdt123/ywdt_1/t17869963.shtml.

Qi, W., and Z. Juxia. 2020. Zhongguo-Dongmeng zhiye jiaoyu hezuo: shijian yangtai yu youhua celüe (Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in vocational education: Practical forms and strategies for optimization). *Zhiye jishu jiaoyu* 27:24–8.

Qiufeng, Z., and Y. Manfu. 2021. Yi dai yi lu" shiyu xia Zhongguo-Dongmeng zhiye jiaoyu hezuo de wenti biaozheng yu tuijin celüe (Characteristics of problems in Chinese-ASEAN cooperation in higher education and strategies for advancement within the field of view of the "Belt and Road"). *Jiaoyu yu zhiye* 7:12–8.

Tirong, Y., D. Xun, and W. Jian. 2023. Yi dai yi lu" changyi shi nian Zhongguo-Dongmeng jiaoyu hezuo chengjiu yu gao zhiliang fazhan lujing (Ten years of achievements in Chinese-ASEAN educational cooperation under the "Belt and Road" Initiative and pathways to high-quality development). *Bijiao jiaoyu yanjiu* 10:39–49.

Xinhua Institute. 2023. "Yi dai yi lu" fazhan xue—quanqiu gongtong fazhan de shijian he lilun tansuo (Studies of "Belt and Road" development—an exploration of practices and theories of common global development) [EB/OL]. (10-19-2023) [07-26-2024]. http://www.xinhuanet.com/2023-10/19/c_1129924747.htm.

Zhidong, L., and Z. Peng. 2016. Bohai "Luban gongfang" Tianjin zhijiao guojihua fazhan de chuangxin zhi ju—zhiye jiaoyu huodong zhou "Yi da iyi lu" jianshe chengguo fenxiang (The innovative moves of the Bohai "Luban Workshop" for the internationalized development of vocational education in Tianjin—sharing achievements in the construction of the "Belt and Road" for Vocational Education Week. *Zhongguo zhiye jishu jiaoyu* 16:56–62.

Zhongchang, W., and H. Jia. 2023. Zhongguo-Dongmeng zhiye jiaoyu guoji hezuo pingtai jianshe de xianzhuang, kunjing yu lujing—jiyu 254 pingtai de fenbu (The current state, difficulties and pathways for construction of international cooperative platforms for Chinese-ASEAN vocational education—based on an analysis of 254 platforms). *Jiaoyu yu zhiye* 4:44–51.